FIRST ANGLO-DUTCH WAR

IN 1651 THE PARLIAMENT of the Commonwealth of England, just emerging from a civil war, passed the first Navigation Act. Stating that all goods brought to England must be carried either in English vessels or those of the country of origin, the act was a deliberate challenge to Dutch domination of maritime trade. The Dutch responded to England's search and seizure of merchant ships by assembling an imposing war fleet to protect merchant convoys and to intimidate the English in the Channel and North Sea. War broke out unintentionally through a naval clash at Dover in May 1652. After an initial setback at the battle of the Kentish Knock, the Dutch scored victories at Dungeness in winter 1652 and at Leghorn in the Mediterranean in spring 1653. But the English improved the organization of their fleet and had the better of a series of fierce encounters at Portland, Gabbard Bank, and Scheveningen. The war exhausted both countries and was ended in April 1654 with a peace treaty that resolved nothing. Unsurprisingly, the Anglo-Dutch contest for maritime supremacy was resumed in the following decade.

FIRST ANGLO-DUTCH WAR

DOVER



Date May 29, 1652
Forces English: 25 ships; Dutch: 47 ships
Losses English: none; Dutch: 2 ships captured

Location Goodwin Sands, off Dover

The English provocatively asserted the right to be saluted by foreign ships in the Channel and the North Sea. Admiral Maarten Tromp, escorting a Dutch merchant convoy down the Channel in May 1652, had been authorized by his government to dip his flag in salute if necessary. On May 29, Tromp met an English squadron commanded by General-at-Sea Robert Blake, whose warning shots hit Tromp's flagship *Brederode*. Tromp replied with a broadside and a general fight ensued. After five hours nightfall brought an end to the exchanges and Tromp escorted his convoy onward. A formal declaration of war followed six weeks later.

FIRST ANGLO-DUTCH WAR

KENTISH KNOCK



Date October 8,1652
Forces English: 68 ships; Dutch: 62 ships
Losses English: none; Dutch: 1 ship sunk, 1 ship captured

Location North Sea, off Thames estuary

By October 1652 the Dutch States-General had lost faith in Admiral Maarten Tromp. They replaced him with Vice-Admiral Witte de With, whose instructions were to seek out and destroy the English fleet. Adopting the *Prins Willem* as his flagship, de With led a fleet of 62 ships to attack the English at their anchorage in the Downs.

Under the overall command of General-at-Sea Robert Blake, the English came out to fight, but bad weather delayed the start of the battle. The two fleets finally met near the sandbank of the Kentish Knock late in the afternoon of October 8. Blake held the weather gage and chose to attack, but the battle started badly for the English when two of their largest ships, *Sovereign* and *James*, ran aground in the shallow channels. While Blake, on board *Resolution*, led an onslaught against de With, the rear English squadron under Rear Admiral Nehemiah Bourne was surrounded by a superior force of Dutch ships commanded by Michiel de Ruyter. Bourne's ships were "very much maimed" before Blake came to their rescue. But the Dutch suffered worse. One ship, *Burgh van Alkmaar,* exploded, and another, *Maria*, was captured. De With was obliged to move his flag after *Prins Willem* lost two masts.

Darkness brought the fighting to a close and saved the Dutch from an even worse defeat. De With failed to convince his captains to continue the battle on the following day, and both he and de Ruyter succeeded in withdrawing without further loss.



1599–1657

ROBERT BLAKE

GENERAL-AT-SEA

Born in Somerset, England, Robert Blake made his name as a Parliamentary land commander during the English Civil War. In 1649 he was appointed General-at-Sea, despite a lack of naval experience. After a sterling performance in the First Anglo-Dutch War, he led a punitive mission against the Barbary pirates in 1655, and in 1657 destroyed a Spanish treasure fleet at Tenerife. He also influenced the drawing up of the Articles of War governing captains' conduct and the adoption of line-of-battle tactics by the English fleet.

FIRST ANGLO-DUTCH WAR

PORTLAND



Date February 28–March 2, 1653
Forces Dutch: c.80 warships; English: c.80 warships
Losses Dutch: 10 warships; English: 1 warship

Location The Channel

On December 10, 1652, reinstated in command of the Dutch fleet, Admiral Maarten Tromp inflicted a significant defeat on the English at Dungeness. As a result, he was able to escort a large convoy of merchant vessels down the Channel to the Atlantic. Tromp then waited at La Rochelle to gather more ships and shepherd them back to the Netherlands—a delay that gave the English time to recover.

The English and Dutch sighted one another at dawn on February 28. Tromp had the weather gage and chose to attack, rather than passively shield his merchant convoy. The English were scattered and General-at-Sea Robert Blake at first had to engage around 30 Dutch ships with only a dozen of his own. Blake's flagship *Triumph* was battered at close range by broadsides from Tromp's *Brederode*, suffering over 100 casualties. But only one English frigate was sunk, while the Dutch lost eight ships as the main body of the English fleet joined the combat. Over the following days a running battle ensued. Though short of powder, the Dutch saved most of their warships and more than half the merchant convoy from capture or destruction.

Running battle
In defense of its merchant convoy, the Dutch fleet descended on the English in the Channel. By the third day, the battle had drifted as far as Kent.



FIRST ANGLO-DUTCH WAR

SCHEVENINGEN



Date August 8-10, 1653
Forces Dutch: 106 ships; English: c.120 ships
Losses Dutch:15 ships; English: none

Location Off the Netherlands

In August 1653 Admiral Maarten Tromp attempted to break a blockade of the Dutch coast by the English fleet under General-at-Sea George Monck. Tromp's ships in the Maas needed to link up with Witte de With's squadron in the Texel. With a brilliant maneuver, on August 8 Tromp drew Monck southward, allowing de With to sortie. With Tromp and de With united, battle was joined. Crossing and recrossing the enemy fleet in line, the English devastated the Dutch ships with their heavy guns. The battle ended with the Dutch in disorganized flight, but they had inflicted enough damage for the English to abandon the blockade.